Step 3: Installing Windows XP

Insert the Windows XP CD into the CD ROM drive and start the Virtual Machine. Wait for Windows Setup to start. As soon as the blue screen appears, check the grey bar at the bottom when it asks you to press F6. As soon as it does (Figure 2), press F6. Nothing may seem to happen at first, but eventually a screen will appear, asking for a *Driver Disk*. Press *S* here.

Now a listing of the drivers on the floppy disk will appear. Select the "Intel(R) 82801HEM/HBM SATA AHCI Controller (Mobile ICH8M-E/M)" driver, the second on the list. Press *Enter* twice. Now the Windows Setup program will start. I'm not going to guide you on how to install XP here—if you aren't sure, google for the relevant how-to article.

Once the installation finishes and you've rebooted to start XP (Figure 3), it's now time to configure it!

Figure 4: Installing VirtualBox Guest Additions

Step 4: Configuring Windows XP

First of all, *update your copy of Windows*. Install the latest Service Pack (which is Service Pack 3), all the hotfixes, Internet Explorer 8, Windows Media Player 11, .NET Frameworks 1.1 through 3.5 and Sun Java. This makes sure you are protected against all security flaws.

Now it's time to install the VirtualBox Guest Additions. From the *Devices* menu in VirtualBox, click *Install Guest Additions*. Follow the wizard (Figure 4), choose to install Direct3D Support when prompted, and reboot at the end of it all. Once it's done and Windows has started up again, go to the *Machine* menu. Prepare to be amazed. Select *Seamless Mode*.

Figure 5: Running XP in 'Seamless Mode'

It might take some time to get used to this. The Windows desktop disappears, and the Windows taskbar sits right on top of the KDE4 or GNOME panel. If you are doing this in KDE, it's best to give it its own Virtual Desktop, where there are no widgets. You will truly love this. Windows applications now look like they are part of the Linux desktop, except for a strange theme and window borders. Refer to Figure 5.

However, *Seamless Mode* does have some limitations, and there are haphazard renderings at times which look like screen corruption. Also, moving windows around the desktop becomes kind of slow, but it really does not annoy. There may be times you'd want to switch to plain old fullscreen mode, but this can be rather buggy. For example, on pressing HostKey+L, the VirtualBox window may just not appear. The only option then would be to switch back to seamless mode by pressing HostKey+L and then rebooting Windows.

The next bit involves all those shared folders. Right-click *My Computer* on the Windows Start Menu, and choose *Map Network Drive*. On the dialogue box that appears, select a *Drive letter*, and in the *Share path* field, type in *\\VBOXSVR\<Share Name>*. For example, if the share name is 'Public', enter the share path as *\\VBOXSVR\Public*. Now, in My Computer, you can access all your shared folders as Drives.

That does it. Our Windows XP Mode is complete. Fire it up, work on it, run all your Windows-only apps with maximum compatibility, share data between the host and guest OS, copy and paste between the two with Shared Clipboards, even do some light gaming. But of course, if you expect it to run Crysis at 1920x1080 and 200FPS, with all settings turned to *Max*, I'm afraid it's asking a bit too much...

The bottom line

Since VirtualBox is cross-platform, you can use it to virtualise XP on Windows 7 as well. If you are adventurous enough, try virtualising Linux on Windows. The installation is easy, but integrating Linux into Windows is not. But if you can do it, you will truly love the results.

Finally, your mileage may vary. END

Since the time the article was written, a new version of VirtualBox has been released which changes the UI in the *Settings* dialog quite a bit. Under the *Storage* section, the configuration is done via a "Storage Tree", where you need to create controllers (IDE, SCSI, SATA and Floppy), and then add devices to it (such as physical drives, ISOs, etc). Everything else remains more or less the same, and the new UI is very self-explanatory.

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